

SPACESHIP EARTH: THE GLOBAL LEGACY OF DR. ALFRED “TUNA” SNIDER

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15th All Asian Championship, Dhaka, Bangladesh, 2008

From left: Dr. Snider (Tabulations Director), Adiba Shareen (Deputy Chief Adjudicator, Malaysia), Jason Jarvis (Deputy Chief Adjudicator, South Korea)

The Mission

While other people are better positioned to comment on Dr. Snider’s legacy in America, I knew him better as an international debate educator. Tuna traveled relentlessly, and it is hard to understate his transnational impact on global argument cultures. I had a front row seat for several of Dr. Snider’s global debate adventures in South Korea, Bangladesh, Slovenia, Thailand, Canada, Ireland and Iraq.

Dr. Snider’s international legacy is summed up by a concept that became code for us when we worked together: “The Mission.” “The Mission” is an activist,

non-profit agenda to encourage global dialogue through debate education. Consequently, this essay is a small effort to recognize and record Tuna's unique contribution to global debate history. "The Mission" encapsulates what makes Dr. Snider unique among American debate educators: his global vision. Dr. Snider was inspirational because he focused on the transnational picture – even when his domestic policy debate colleagues remained focused on America. He saw debate as a tool for global dialogue and he put that tool into practice.

The remainder of this essay explores Tuna's legacy through two examples of "The Mission." First, I discuss Dr. Snider's impact on the growth of debate in South Korea. Second, I review the Iraq Debate Academy and Dr. Snider's effort to promote debate in Iraq. South Korea and Iraq demonstrate the unpredictable ripple effects that the creation of the World Debate Institute in Burlington, Vermont had on argument cultures globally. Tuna was planting seeds of peace, one student at a time. As those seeds began to sprout, the Lawrence Debate Union, housed at the University of Vermont, gave rise to a global network of debate advocates.

South Korea: Spaceship Earth

"Spaceship Earth" is a slogan that summarized Dr. Snider's belief that humanity faces shared problems and needs to use dialogue in order to find workable solutions. It is a term that Dr. Snider used annually when he delivered the last lecture at the World Debate Institute (WDI). It was a term that had real meaning for Tuna, as his global debate efforts make clear. While the WDI initially engaged European argument cultures, it had an impact on Asia. Through the WDI, the Lawrence Debate Union was essential in starting debate in South Korea.



Asian Debate Institute, Seoul, South Korea, 2005.

From left: Loke Wing Fatt (Singapore), Dr. Snider, Bojana Skrt (Slovenia), Dr. Omar Salahuddin (Malaysia)

In August of 2000, Kyung Hee University Communication Professor Dr. Gyeong-ho Hur found Debate Central online, read about WDI and concluded that debate would be good for his South Korean students. During the WDI, I became friends with Dr. Hur. Two years later, Dr. Hur arranged a job for me at Kyung Hee University, and I moved to Seoul. "Spaceship Earth" took on a personal meaning for me, as I became "the foreigner" in a middle-class Korean neighborhood. Officially, I was a Lecturer in the Communication Department, responsible for teaching classes. Unofficially, I was tasked with establishing a university debate team and trying to jump-start a local debate community. For the first two years, I basically failed. Debate did not fit easily into a Confucian culture. During this time, Tuna was a touchstone and a voice of encouragement.

In 2004 and 2005, debate began to expand rapidly

in Seoul. With the help of Ewha University Professor Dr. Brendan Howe, we held two tournaments in two years. The UVM debate community supported our efforts by sending students and teachers to events in Seoul. Dr. Steven Woods and Professor John Meany sent teams to the North East Asian Open from Western Washington University and The Claremont Colleges. In 2004, the first Asian Debate Institute (ADI) was held with 30 students from Kyung Hee University and Ewha Woman's University. The ADI was modeled on the World Debate Institute hosted by the Dr. Snider and the Lawrence Debate Union at UVM. Lawrence Debate Union alum, Dr. Maxwell Schnurer, was a faculty member. His passion and energy for debate was contagious and set the tone for a "logic and love" approach to debate education. Dr. Schnurer epitomized the core values of the ADI: harnessing debate competition as a tool for teaching logic and critical thinking, while establishing a foundation for community by promoting mutual love and respect for your opponents. Pia Kim, Andrea Yoo-Sun Choi, Kerry Lee, Eun Joo Seo, and Hyemi Kim were students at the first ADI and soon began leading the South Korean debate community.

In 2005, Dr. Snider and Bojana Skrt were faculty members at the ADI. The workshop split into two halves. During the first week, the Asian High School Debate Institute was offered to high school students for the first time and served just under 100 students. In an effort to draw in a transnational student body from across Asia, the university workshop was rebranded in 2005 as World Debate Institute - Asia. The expanded workshop drew a faculty of debate luminaries from across Asia including Omar Salahuddin (Malaysia), Eleanor Uy (Philippines), Logandran Balavijendran (Malaysia), Loke Wing Fatt (Singapore), Dan Williams (South Korea), Iqbal Hafiedz (Malaysia), Pascual Garcia

(Philippines) and Masako Suzuki (Japan).

Ewha University debater Dohhee Roh was among the high school students who participated in the second Asian Debate Institute. In a *Facebook* post from December 12, 2015 she describes the significance of Tuna's work in South Korea:

Having been one of the first high school students to ever attend ADI, and also having been one of those truly inspired by Tuna in that particular tourney/camp, I am having a hard time putting my feeling into words. (Roh, 2015)

The Asian Debate Institute is a product of the "The Mission," and it is still held annually by the students of Chung Ang University in Seoul. The ADI has educated thousands of students from across Northeast Asia with regular attendees from China and Japan as well as South Korea.

The current debate community in South Korea is what happens when people work together and practice "logic and love" on "Spaceship Earth." The success of the efforts to promote English language debate in South Korea was not a foregone conclusion. Teaching argument to a society predicated on Confucian values is an inherently difficult project as demonstrated by early failures to transplant American policy debate to the Hermit Kingdom. Dr. Snider and the Lawrence Debate Union were instrumental in the creation of the debate community in South Korea because the global vision that spawned the World Debate Institute led to a global network of debate educators who volunteered intellectual energy, personal time and pedagogical support to local volunteers in Seoul.

Iraq: Replacing Weapons With Words



Lunch at the Iraq Debate Academy, December 2009 Foreground from left: Jonathan Borock (Japan), Megan Harlow (UVM), Dr. Snider

Nothing characterizes the meaning of “The Mission” more than Dr. Snider’s willingness to teach debate in conflict zones. “Replacing weapons with words” is a phrase that appeared on World Debate Institute t-shirts. It was always my favorite “Tunaism,” or frequent Tuna saying, because argument offers a way to avoid conflict escalation through an analysis of evidence in a passionate but respectful way. Most importantly, debate requires you to take the role of the other, facilitating critical listening. When we had dinner for the last time in October of 2015, Tuna was preparing for an upcoming debate workshop in Palestine. There are few other places in which one could imagine “replacing weapons with words” would have more meaning or importance.

Through his work in South Korea, Dr. Snider also became involved in efforts to encourage debate in Iraq. A little-known fact is that South Korea contributed the 3rd largest amount of troops to the United States

coalition efforts to support the second Bush invasion in Iraq. Consequently, many Iraqi students came to South Korea to attend universities and participate in international exchange programs. Muhammad Ahmad took my debate classes in Seoul and attended the All Asian Debate Championship as a volunteer. Dr. Snider and Bojana Skrt met Muhammad when he attended the Asian Debate Institute as a student. Muhammad was passionate about debate and committed to trying to host a debate workshop in his hometown: Dohuk, a city north of Erbil in the Kurdish region of Iraq. Eventually, Muhammad succeeded in getting local sponsorship from the regional government, and a band of volunteers made the journey to northern Iraq in December of 2009.



Iraq Debate Academy Faculty: (from left) Jason Jarvis, Megan Harlow, Dr. Snider, Bojana Skrt, Matt Stannard, Jonathan Borock.

The Iraq Debate Academy was an intense educational experience for both the faculty and the students. The workshop was culturally diverse and featured university students from the northern and southern regions of Iraq. Kurdish, Yazidi, and Arab.

Shia and Sunni. Iraqi, Slovenian, and American. We came together for a week of dialogue and education. The workshop used British Parliamentary format, and topics were carefully chosen in consultation with local workshop organizers to be both culturally sensitive and easily relatable to the students. The opening and closing ceremonies of the Iraq Debate Academy were covered by local news organizations and broadcast on Kurdish television.

The debates were challenging to judge because students brought so much personal experience into their arguments. A faculty full of Americans met the implications of the US invasion of Iraq head on. On December 17, 2009, I sent this email to my family in America:

At two different times after a debate has ended, I sincerely wanted to cry. During my first debate at the workshop about whether US troops should stay in Iraq, I heard about how life was better before the invasion. A student who is half Kurd and half Arab talked about the fact that life was normal here until we invaded. I was told people had to flee or starve or lose years of their education because it wasn't safe to go to work or to school. Apparently, Iraqi's thought that they were different than places that had terrorism like Palestine or Afghanistan, because there was none here until we "liberated" them. Yesterday, two students revealed in a debate about the death penalty that their parents had been murdered by terrorists since the invasion.

My experiences as a judge were typical of what all of the faculty members learned in their debates as Dr. Snider explained on the World Debate Institute Blog in December of 2009:

One thing is very clear, debate is here, the

people of Iraq are ready for debate as an alternative to violence, and hopefully this will make a positive difference. I know that I have learned a huge amount, that I have been honored and humbled by these students and the organizers and that I will certainly never be the same.

The death penalty debate is one I will never forget because of how passionate each of the students was in wanting to assess the merits of the death penalty in relation to whether it should have been used on Saddam Hussein. Saddam used chemical weapons against the Kurds, so everyone was invested in the issue on a personal level (Barbati, 2013).

The legacy: Thinking and speaking a better world

There are two lessons that I hope people draw from "The Mission" and the life of Dr. Snider. First, "The Mission" was about learning from other argument cultures and building bridges outside of our comfort zone. One of the dangers facing policy debate is its American-centric myopia. Dr. Snider's description of our home as "Spaceship Earth" rather than the United States, implores Americans to look beyond our borders and engage the rest of the planet. There are thriving debate communities and budding argument cultures all over the world: **some** of these communities need American help. However, while there is value in us sharing our knowledge with the planet, there is also much for Americans to learn from how debate (and life) is practiced in different parts of the world. In both South Korea and Iraq, faculty members learned as much, if not more, than the students attending the workshop.

Second, "The Mission" was based on developing new platforms for global dialogue. Dr. Snider was a visionary when it came to recognizing new

opportunities to advance global debate education. He constantly supported new debate formats. NDT. CEDA. Parliamentary (in multiple forms). No format is perfect and all debate is good debate if it allows for critical thinking and education to take place.

Tuna was savvy about using information technology. Debate Central is among the first websites to host any debate content, and it was built long before people really understood the transformational significance of networked technology. Debate Central gave Tuna access to a global community waking up to the Internet. Debate Central also gave the Lawrence Debate Union a transnational platform where people could consider our global problems by watching debates, Flashpoint episodes and accessing debate education materials.

Like many people, I feel a hole in my life where Dr. Snider used to be. Dr. Snider's travel schedule made many people (me included) envious, but it was also grueling and should be understood as part of the sacrifice he made for debate and the world. Through debate, Tuna found a platform where he could chip away at the problems facing the planet. He managed to "be a link turn." To honor his legacy, as citizens of Spaceship Earth, we should strive to practice "Logic and Love," and work daily to "Replace Weapons with Words."





Even the great ones practice their lectures. *Iraq Debate Academy, December 2009*

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